

INTERNATIONAL news

Nvidia finalises \$5 billion stake in Intel

Nvidia has invested \$5 billion in Intel, acquiring over 214 million shares at \$23.28 each, providing a financial boost to the struggling chipmaker. Approved by US antitrust authorities, the private placement strengthens Intel's capital position as it pursues large-scale expansion, while marking a notable collaboration between two longtime competitors in the global semiconductor industry.

China halts rare earth exports to Japan

China has imposed an immediate ban on exports of selected rare earth minerals and dual-use items to Japan, escalating tensions after Japan's prime minister's remarks on Taiwan. Beijing cited national security concerns. Japan condemned the move. With 60% import dependence, economists warn that a prolonged ban could cut GDP by 0.11% and disrupt vehicle supply chains.

Ford takes \$19.5 billion hit and rethinks EVs

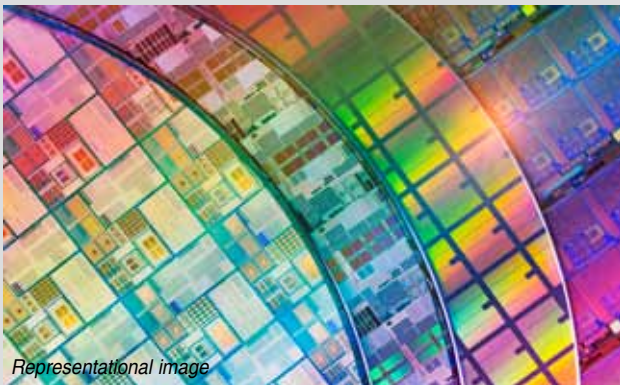
Ford is overhauling its EV strategy, dissolving the BlueOval SK battery joint venture with SK On and taking about \$19.5 billion in special charges amid weaker EV demand. Ford will take full ownership of Kentucky battery plants and repurpose them for energy storage, while SK On will run the Tennessee site. The shift includes cancelling some EV models and refocusing on hybrids and smaller EVs.

EIB and STMicroelectronics seal €1 billion funding deal

The European Investment Bank (EIB) has agreed to a €1 billion financing package with STMicroelectronics to strengthen Europe's semiconductor industry. The first €500 million tranche will support manufacturing scale-up in Italy and France, as well as R&D into advanced chip technologies. The deal, the EIB's 9th with STMicroelectronics, reinforces Europe's push for semiconductor competitiveness, innovation, and energy-efficient technologies.

TSMC begins mass production of cutting-edge 2nm chips

TSMC has begun mass production of its 2nm chips, its most advanced technology to date, at Fabs 20 and 22 in Hsinchu and Kaohsiung, respectively. Volume production started in Q4 2025



Representational image

as planned. The 2nm process delivers higher performance and energy efficiency, supporting rising global demand for advanced AI chips.

AI boom lifts Foxconn's fourth quarter revenue by 22%

Foxconn reported record Q4 2025 revenue growth of 22.07% YoY, driven by strong global demand for AI hardware. Quarterly revenue reached T\$2.6 trillion, exceeding expectations, led by AI server orders for customers such as Nvidia. December revenue reached a record T\$862.9 billion, up nearly 32% YoY, while resilient AI server demand is expected to support early-2026 performance.

Elon Musk's xAI secures \$20 billion in Nvidia-backed funding

Elon Musk's xAI has raised \$20 billion in an oversubscribed funding round to accelerate development of its Grok AI models. Backed by investors including Fidelity, Qatar Investment Authority, and Nvidia, the funding will support large-scale model training, data centre expansion, and the development of new products. xAI said its Memphis facilities now host over 1 million Nvidia GPUs and are training Grok 5.

Trump blocks \$3 million chip deal, citing security and China concerns

President Donald Trump has blocked a roughly \$3 million chips-related deal involving the US photonics firm HieFo Corp, citing national security and China-linked concerns. The order requires HieFo to divest Emcore assets within 180 days after CFIUS flags risks tied to foreign control of sensitive semiconductor and defence-related technologies.

US allows Samsung and SK Hynix to ship chip equipment to China

The US has granted annual licences to Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix, allowing them to ship chipmaking equipment to their China operations through 2026. The move offers short-term relief amid tightening US export controls, as broader exemptions expired at the end of 2025. China remains vital for memory chip production, especially as AI-driven demand boosts global supply pressures.

Nvidia acquires AI chip startup Groq for \$20 billion

Nvidia is buying assets from AI chip startup Groq for about \$20 billion, marking its largest acquisition to date. Groq's processors and licensed technology will be integrated into Nvidia's AI platform to strengthen inference and real-time workloads. Groq will continue operating independently, while some executives join Nvidia, underscoring intensified competition in the fast-growing AI chip market.

VinFast linked GSM targets international IPO

Vietnam's electric taxi operator, GSM, is considering an overseas IPO, potentially in Hong Kong by 2027, with advisors citing a possible valuation of up to \$20 billion. Backed by Vingroup and using VinFast vehicles, GSM operates Vietnam's largest EV taxi fleet. A listing would fund regional expansion and help ease financial pressure on Vingroup amid VinFast's capital-intensive growth.

Chinese AI chipmaker Biren raises US\$716.85 million in Hong Kong IPO

Chinese AI chipmaker Shanghai Biren Technology raised HK\$5.58 billion (\$717 million) in its Hong Kong IPO, with institutional investors oversubscribing 26 times and retail buyers 2348 times. Pricing at HK\$19.60 per share, the offering underscores strong confidence in China's semiconductor push. Founded in 2019, Biren develops AI processors, including the BR100, that aim to rival Nvidia.

Qualcomm buys RISC-V specialist Ventana to strengthen CPU roadmap

Qualcomm has acquired RISC-V CPU startup Ventana Micro Systems to advance its next-generation processor technologies. Ventana's expertise will support Qualcomm's Oryon CPU roadmap, enhancing PCs, servers, edge computing, and AI products. The acquisition builds on prior Nuvia and Alphawave deals, strengthening Qualcomm's position in high-performance, energy-efficient compute amid rising demand for scalable AI and data centre solutions.